

KY.4 Where to File Directory

Kentucky's hardest question is not what the rules are — it is whether anyone will inspect your house, and who. This document answers it and gives you a page to write down what you confirmed.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. Kentucky writes one mandatory residential code for the whole state — and then leaves the building permit, the inspections and the certificate of occupancy to each of its 120 counties and its cities, some of which require them and many of which do not. The state plumbing permit and the electrical certificate of approval apply either way. Confirm every item with the office that will actually handle your parcel before you rely on it.

ONE CODE, AND UP TO SIX DIFFERENT ANSWERS

The Kentucky Residential Code is the same in all 120 counties. Who enforces it is not. On a single parcel you can be dealing with a county building inspector, a city building inspector, a **state** plumbing inspector out of Frankfort, a state or local HVAC inspector, a certified electrical inspector arranged through your county judge/executive, and a health department environmentalist — and in much of the state, no building inspector at all.

Six questions, six possible offices

Permit or approval	Who handles it
Building	Local, or nobody. Only if your city or county passed an ordinance requiring permits and inspections for single-family dwellings. The State is barred from filling the gap. (KRS 198B.060(1), (4)(b))
Plumbing	State by default. The permit comes from the Department of Housing, Buildings and Construction. A local government that has been authorized may issue instead, and its permit " <i>shall be deemed a permit issued by the department</i> " — but the department keeps concurrent jurisdiction. (KRS 318.134(1)(a); 318.140(1))
HVAC	State, or a local program that already existed in 2007. No local government may start a new HVAC permitting or inspection program — the door closed on January 1, 2007. (KRS 198B.6671(1); 198B.6673(2), (4))
Electrical	A certified electrical inspector — employed by, or contracted with, the local government, or a state inspector. Your power company cannot connect you permanently without their final certificate of approval. (KRS 198B.060(11))
Septic	Your county health department , under the Cabinet for Health and Family Services. Its permit must accompany your state plumbing application. (KRS 318.134(2))

Six questions, six possible offices

Permit or approval	Who handles it
Zoning	City or county planning — an entirely separate question from building permits, and not answered by any of the above. Many Kentucky counties have zoning but no building permits

The mistake this document exists to prevent

Owner-builders arriving in Kentucky from a state with universal permitting assume that somebody, somewhere, will tell them what to do. In much of Kentucky nobody will — and the reason is statutory, not administrative. Permits, inspections and certificates of occupancy are not mandatory for a single-family residence unless the local government passed an ordinance, and the department *"shall not preempt or assert jurisdiction for the enforcement of the code on single-family dwellings."*

Working through the Department's own county inspector sheets — all 119 of them — 25 print "None" for Local Building Inspector, 6 carry the heading with nothing after it, and 10 have no such line at all. That is 41 of 119, about one county in three. The 25 word it in a way that says everything: *"None / For Commercial construction Contact Dept. Housing, Buildings Construction for building permits."* The State will handle a warehouse there. For your house, there is nobody.

And the other 78 overstate the coverage. Several name an inspector for a city only — the sheets say things like "City Limits ONLY" or "(No County Building Inspector)" — so a named inspector on your county's sheet does not mean the whole county is covered. If your parcel is outside the city limits, ask again.

Treat all of this as a measure of how common the gap is, not as a lookup. The sheets are a contact list of inspectors, not a register of ordinances: a city inside one of those counties may still require permits, and a county with a named inspector may still not require them for houses. Only your own city and county can tell you which side of the line your parcel is on — which is why the first checklist in KY.1 is two phone calls.

THE COUNTY INSPECTOR SHEET — KENTUCKY'S BEST-KEPT SECRET

The Department publishes a **one-page PDF for every county** naming the actual people who inspect there: your state electrical inspector, your plumbing inspector and the hours they keep, the HVAC inspector, the health department environmentalist who handles your septic, and whether a local building inspector exists at all. It is free, it is current, and almost nobody outside the trade knows it exists.

Find it at **dhbc.ky.gov** → **HOW DO I?** → **Contact an Inspector**, then click your county.



Open **your county's sheet** and read the **Local Building Inspector** line first. If it says *None*, or the line is not there at all, your county has no local building inspector — go back to KY.1 and confirm with your city and county whether any permit ordinance applies to you.

- ☐ Write down the **Plumbing Inspector** and — this is the useful part — the **office hours and office address** printed underneath. In most counties that address is the **county health department**, which is also where your septic permit comes from. Two of your approvals live in the same building.
- ☐ Write down the **State Electrical Inspector**. Every published sheet names one. Where the sheet says "*Local Electrical Inspector: contact the County Judge Executive's office or City office where work is to be performed,*" that is the real answer for most of rural Kentucky — start with the judge/executive's office.
- ☐ Write down the **HVAC Inspector** and the **Health Dept. Environmentalist**.
- ☐ Check the **"Updated" date** in the bottom corner. Most sheets were revised in 2026, but some are older — if yours is, confirm the names before you rely on them.
- ☐ **Building in Gallatin County?** There is no published sheet for it. Contact the Department directly and write the answers below.

*Department of Housing, Buildings and Construction county inspector sheets, dhbc.ky.gov → Contact an Inspector, all downloaded and tallied 27 August 2026: **119 sheets published for 120 counties** — Gallatin has none. Of the 119, **25 print "None"** for Local Building Inspector, **6 leave the field empty** and **10 carry no such line** — 41 in total — while 78 name someone, several of them for a city only. 117 sheets carry an update stamp: 70 revised in 2026, 41 in 2025, 6 in 2024. The classification of the agency's wording is the author's; sheet formats vary, and some counties combine roles.*

THE OFFICES THE COUNTY SHEET DOES NOT COVER

The sheet settles the inspectors. It says nothing about the approvals that are not inspections — and on a rural Kentucky parcel those are usually the ones that take the longest.

Finding the right office for your parcel

Office	How to find it
Zoning and planning (use, setbacks, lot size, subdivision)	Your city or county planning commission , or the county judge/executive's office where there is no commission. Entirely separate from building permits — a county with no building permit may still have zoning, and a county with zoning may have no building permit. Ask for setbacks in writing before you draw.
911 address assignment	Usually the county 911 or emergency services office , sometimes the property valuation administrator. You will need an address before the utilities will set an account, so do this early rather than late.
Driveway / entrance permit	If you tie in to a state-maintained route , the Kentucky Transportation Cabinet's district office issues the encroachment or entrance permit — transportation.ky.gov . If the road is county-maintained, it is the county road department. Confirm which authority owns your road before assuming.

Finding the right office for your parcel

Office	How to find it
Floodplain	Kentucky administers floodplain construction at the state level through the Energy and Environment Cabinet's Division of Water — eec.ky.gov . This can apply even where your county has no building permit and no local floodplain ordinance, so check your parcel against the flood maps before you buy, not after.
Septic and private well	Your county health department , under the Cabinet for Health and Family Services — chfs.ky.gov . The environmentalist named on your county inspector sheet is the person. Start here first: the septic permit gates the state plumbing permit by statute.
Electric utility	Your rural electric cooperative or investor-owned utility. They need the certified electrical inspector's final certificate of approval before permanent service, and they set their own requirements for the service point, meter base and pole. Ask for their construction requirements in writing at the start.
Water district	If you are on public water rather than a well, the water district cannot give you permanent service until the plumbing is approved (KRS 318.165). Tap fees are theirs and are often the largest single permit-related cost on the job.

YOUR DIRECTORY — FILL THIS IN BEFORE YOU NEED IT

Start with the question that governs everything else, then work down. Confirm each answer with the office itself rather than copying it from a search result, and note the name of the person you spoke to — in a county office a name is worth more than a number.

THE QUESTION THAT GOVERNS EVERYTHING ELSE — does a building permit exist where you are building?

City requires a building permit? (Y/N): _____ Confirmed with: _____

County requires one? (Y/N): _____ Confirmed with: _____

BUILDING PERMIT — city or county — or write NONE REQUIRED

Office / person: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

STATE PLUMBING INSPECTOR — name, office hours and office address from your county sheet

Office / person: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

HVAC INSPECTOR — state, or a local program predating 2007

Office / person: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

CERTIFIED ELECTRICAL INSPECTOR — the final certificate of approval your power company needs

Office / person: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

HEALTH DEPARTMENT — septic permit and the environmentalist's name

Office / person: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

ZONING / PLANNING — setbacks, use, lot requirements

Office / person: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

911 ADDRESSING — you need the address before the utilities will set an account

Office / person: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

ROAD / DRIVEWAY PERMIT — Transportation Cabinet district, or county road department

Office / person: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

ELECTRIC UTILITY — temporary construction power and permanent service

Office / person: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

WATER & SEWER — public connection and tap fees — or N/A if well and septic

Office / person: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

STATE-LEVEL CONTACTS

These are stable and worth knowing. Phone numbers are left for you to write in — a wrong number printed in a kit is worse than no number.

State agencies and what each is actually for

Agency	Why you would contact them	Website
Department of Housing, Buildings and Construction	Publishes the county inspector sheets and the currently-adopted code list; issues the state plumbing and HVAC permits; licenses electricians, plumbers and HVAC contractors and certifies electrical and building inspectors. Also where you verify that a contractor you are hiring actually holds the license they claim.	dhbc.ky.gov
Kentucky General Assembly	The statutes and regulations themselves, free and current: KRS Chapter 198B (building code), 227A (electrical), 318 (plumbing), and KAR Title 815 (Housing, Buildings and Construction).	apps.legislature.ky.gov
Cabinet for Health and Family Services	On-site sewage disposal — the septic permit that must accompany your state plumbing application — administered through your county health department.	chfs.ky.gov
Energy and Environment Cabinet	Division of Water: floodplain construction, stream crossings, water well driller certification and construction stormwater permits.	eec.ky.gov
Kentucky Transportation Cabinet	Entrance and encroachment permits where a driveway meets a state-maintained route. Work through the district office that covers your county.	transportation.ky.gov

Sources (verified August 2026). *Local option and the bar on state preemption for single-family dwellings* — KRS 198B.060(1), (4)(b), (8), (13); 815 KAR 7:125 Section 2(2)(a). *State plumbing permit and local authorization* — KRS 318.134(1)(a); 318.140(1). *Septic permit accompanying the plumbing application* — KRS 318.134(2). *HVAC permit, and the bar on new local HVAC programs after January 1, 2007* — KRS 198B.6671(1); 198B.6673(2), (4). *Certified electrical inspector and permanent service* — KRS 198B.060(11). *No permanent water until the plumbing is approved* — KRS 318.165. *County inspector sheets* — dhbc.ky.gov, downloaded 27 August 2026. All four agency websites above returned a live page on that date.